in the process of copying DNA – not to a failure to represent reality accurately. A mutation that inhibits the production of adrenaline reduces fitness, causing the network of cells to disintegrate, as when the zebra is killed and its trillions of cells lose connection with one another. But this kind of network failure means disintegration not disinformation. That's as true of countries, political parties and news networks as it is of zebras. Their existence too is jeopardised by loss of contact between their constituent parts, more than by inaccurate representations of reality.

Crucially, errors in the copying of DNA don't always reduce fitness. Once in a blue moon, they increase fitness. Without such mutations, there would be no process of evolution. All life-forms exist thanks to genetic 'errors'. The wonders of evolution are possible because DNA doesn't represent any pre-existing realities; it creates new realities.

Let us pause to digest the implications of this. Information is something that creates new realities by connecting different points into a network. This still includes the view of information as representation. Sometimes, a truthful representation of reality can connect humans, as when 600 million people sat glued to their television sets in July 1969, watching Neil Armstrong and Buzz Aldrin walking on the moon.[14] The images on the screens accurately represented what was happening 384,000 kilometres away, and seeing them gave rise to feelings of awe, pride and human brotherliness that helped connect people.

However, such fraternal feelings can be produced in other ways, too. The emphasis on connection leaves ample room for other types of information that do not represent reality well. Sometimes erroneous representations of reality might also serve as a social nexus, as when millions of followers of a conspiracy theory watch a YouTube video claiming that the moon landing never happened. These images convey an erroneous representation of reality, but they might nevertheless give rise to feelings of anger against the establishment or pride in one's own wisdom that help create a cohesive new group.

Sometimes networks can be connected without *any* attempt to represent reality, neither accurate nor erroneous, as when genetic information connects trillions of cells or when a stirring musical piece connects thousands of humans.

As a final example, consider Mark Zuckerberg's vision of the Metaverse. The Metaverse is a virtual universe made entirely of information. Unlike